KenTender Module Guide: Bid Opening

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What Bid Opening is for

Bid Opening is the formal opening of the sealed bids after the submission deadline. A committee opens them one at a time, reads out each bid's main facts and records them, and bidders may attend and listen. Until the opening starts, nobody can see a bid or tell how many there are.

The Accounting Officer appoints the committee: at least three people, one of them independent. When the deadline passes, the tender box closes by itself. The opening can then start only when every member is present and signed in, and the system checks this again before each bid. Each bid that arrived in time is opened, numbered and read out: the bidder's name, the total price and the tender security offered. Nothing is corrected and no bid is disqualified at the opening; anything that looks wrong is noted for the evaluators. The members then sign the minutes, which the system calls the opening record, and the opened bids pass to Evaluation automatically.

The first release covers the same purchases as the earlier modules: off-the-shelf IT equipment, bought by open tender as a single lot, in Kenya Shillings.

Why it matters: the opening is open and beyond dispute. Bidders hear what was submitted, no price can be seen early or changed after it is read out, and the signed minutes answer any later question about what happened.

Who uses it

Only people named to the committee take part. A job title alone gives no role in the opening.

Who	What they do
Accounting Officer	Appoints the committee and can change it, with the history kept. Publishes how the public can attend. Records why an opening was not held, and decides what happens when an opening cannot go ahead. Cannot open a bid for a member.
Chair	A committee member who runs the opening and starts it once the deadline has passed and every condition is met. Notes which pages of each bid the members must sign. Cannot act for an absent member.
Committee members	At least three in all, including one independent member. Each signs in personally and must stay present throughout. Reads bids' facts aloud and signs the minutes personally. Cannot score or disqualify a bid, or sign for anyone else.
Recorder	Records who came and went, every request and comment, and the reading of each bid. Prepares the minutes. Cannot change a member's signature.
Bidders and their representatives	May attend and hear the facts read out. A supplier that submitted a bid can ask for a copy of the final list of bids. Nobody sees another bidder's full bid.
Head of Procurement Function and Procurement Officers not on the committee	Can read the results once the bids have been opened. Take no part in the opening.
Auditor	Reads the full history of an opening, including who looked at problem reports. Changes nothing and sees no bid before it is opened.

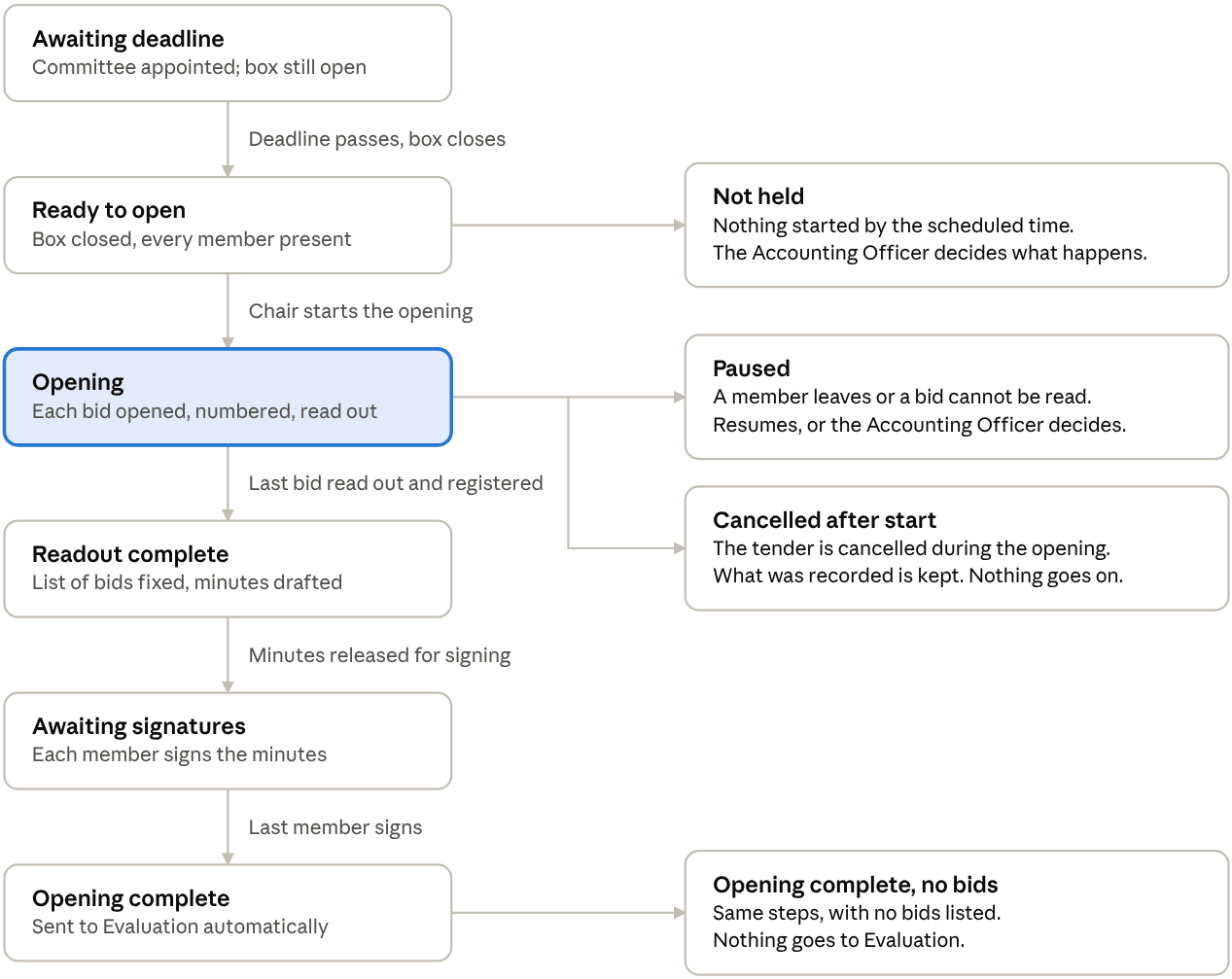
Who	What they do
Opening access support	A technical officer assigned to fix problems with opening the sealed bids. Sees only the problems assigned to them, never a bid, a count or a bidder.
System administrators	See whether the service is running. Learn nothing about a sealed bid, and have no access to problem reports.

The independent member cannot later be appointed to handle or evaluate the same tender. Other members may join the evaluation committee only after its own conflict checks. Nobody who has been given the tender-security intake duty for the tender can sit on the committee, and a committee member cannot be given that duty. The system refuses either appointment without revealing whether any security was received.

From appointment to signed minutes

An opening follows a fixed order, and no step can be skipped. The people running it see three stages: prepare, open the bids, and record the opening.

An opening is complete only when every bid is read out and signed for



opening lifecycle · six states, four side branches

1. **Prepare.** When a tender is published, the system sets up its opening. The Accounting Officer appoints the committee and publishes when and how the public can attend, in person or by link. The opening cannot start without this.
2. **Deadline.** The tender box closes automatically. Nobody on the opening side can yet see how many bids it holds.
3. **Members join.** Each member signs in personally. The box can be unlocked only with the separate participation of the required members, the independent member included; no single person can unlock it. This step is the same whether the box is full or empty, so it reveals nothing about the number of bids.

4. **Start.** The chair starts the opening once the deadline has passed, every member is present, the attendance details are published and the required members have taken part in unlocking the box. Neither the chair nor an administrator can override any of these. Only now does anyone see how many bids there are.
5. **Open each bid.** Bids are opened one at a time, and before each one the system checks again that every member is present. The system checks that the bid has not changed since it was submitted, numbers it and counts its pages. A member reads out the bidder's name, the total and the security offered. The recorder confirms the reading, and the system records the figures exactly as submitted; nobody types or edits an amount. Requests to repeat a figure, and comments, are recorded too.
6. **Prepare the minutes.** After the last bid, the chair ends the opening and the list of bids is fixed. The system drafts the minutes from what was recorded: who was present, what was said and what was read out. The recorder checks them and releases them for signing.
7. **Sign.** Each member signs for themselves: the designated pages of every bid, each price, and the pages of the minutes. If the minutes have to be corrected before they are final, earlier signatures no longer count and everyone signs again.
8. **Complete.** When the last signature is in, the opening completes by itself and the opened bids go to Evaluation.

Only current bids that arrived on time are opened. A withdrawn bid is kept on record but not opened, an earlier version that was replaced stays in the history, and unsubmitted drafts and late attempts never reach the opening.

Is it ready for live use? The opening works end to end on the demonstration site, using test services to lock and unlock the box, run the public attendance link and take signatures. Before live use, the owner must approve the real arrangements: who holds the keys, how many people must take part in unlocking, how members sign and how a failure is recovered. Until then, live openings are unavailable, and the chair is told so plainly.

What is read out and recorded

The opening produces two things: a list of the bids and the signed minutes. Both record facts and make no judgement.

The list of bids. Each bid that arrived in time gets one line: its number, the bidder's name, the total price in Kenya Shillings exactly as submitted, the security offered, and who read it out and when. The total is never corrected at the opening; checking the arithmetic is the evaluators' job.

The security offered. The reading states what the bidder offered, such as a bank guarantee with its reference and amount. Whether it is acceptable is for Evaluation to decide. A paper original or an issuer's confirmation received separately is linked to the bid only once the opening has started.

Who was there. Members, the recorder, observers and bidders' representatives are recorded as they arrive and leave. Attending is optional for suppliers and has no bearing on their bid. Someone who says they represent a bidder is recorded as saying so; that does not show the supplier actually bid.

Requests and comments. A request to repeat a figure is recorded with the answer. A comment that may matter later, such as a security reference that differs from the one read out, can be noted for the evaluators without deciding anything. A member who sees events differently can record that in their own words, and nobody else can write it for them.

Problems with a bid. No bid is rejected at the opening. An apparent defect is recorded and passed on. A bid that cannot be opened, or does not match what the tender box recorded at the deadline, can never be dropped or swapped: the opening waits until the problem is resolved and the outcome recorded.

Times. The system stamps each reading with its own clock. If the recorder notes a different time at which something was said, it is kept separately, labelled as reported, and never used to backdate the record.

The minutes after signing. Once final, the minutes can only be added to. A correction, such as a fix to an attendance note or an observer's name, is linked to the original with its reason, and can never change a bid, an amount or a signed page.

Copies for bidders. A supplier that submitted a bid can ask for the final list of bids once the opening is complete. The system confirms it is a bidder; the Accounting Officer then sends the list or declines with a reason, and the supplier is told either way. It never receives another bidder's bid or the internal minutes.

In the demonstration data, eight openings are complete, with 18 bids between them, and all eight have gone to Evaluation. Two tenders are still open for bids, and the openings of the two cancelled tenders never started.

When an opening cannot go ahead as planned

An opening can go wrong in several ways. None of them may end with a bid quietly dropped, a record made up or a deadline moved, and each has a named person who decides what happens next.

What happens	What the system does
The box holds no bids	The committee follows the same steps. Only after the start does the screen say there are no bids. The chair ends the opening, the members still sign, and the minutes record that there were no bids to evaluate. Nothing goes to Evaluation, and the tender is not cancelled automatically; the Accounting Officer may decide separately what to do.
A member is missing before the start	The opening cannot start. The chair sees who has not joined and can remind them.
A member leaves after the start	The opening pauses before the next bid. The member can sign in again and continue. If they cannot, the Accounting Officer appoints a replacement, who takes part from that point. The minutes show who was actually present, and the number of members required never drops.
A bid cannot be opened, or does not match the deadline record	The opening pauses while opening access support investigates. The chair can try again once support has recorded a fix. The bid is never replaced or left out. If support cannot fix it, the Accounting Officer decides how to proceed.
The opening service or the public attendance link is down before the start	The chair is told the opening is not available and can report it to support; repeated reports count as one problem. If it cannot be fixed, the Accounting Officer records the opening as not held.

What happens	What the system does
The opening is not held	After the scheduled time, if nothing has started, the Accounting Officer records why. That is final: the opening can never be started or resumed. The bids stay sealed and nothing goes to Evaluation. The Accounting Officer decides what happens next, but cancelling a tender after its deadline is not yet available, and the screen says so.
The tender is cancelled before the start	The opening is recorded as never started. The Accounting Officer has nothing further to decide here.
The tender is cancelled during the opening	The opening stops at once. What was recorded so far is kept, no normal minutes are produced and nothing goes to Evaluation.

Each problem with opening the sealed bids is logged as a problem report. The committee and the Accounting Officer see a summary for their own opening. Only the assigned support officer, the chair and the Accounting Officer can see a report's details, and each time they must give a reason. Every such look is logged, and only the Auditor and the Accounting Officer can read that log.

What the rest of the system takes from Bid Opening

Bid Opening ends where evaluation begins. It passes on facts and the unchanged bids, and makes no evaluation decision.

Module	What it takes
Evaluation	For an opening with bids, everything evaluators need, sent once: the opened bids exactly as submitted, the evaluation rules the tender published, the list of bids, the signed minutes, any problems and comments noted for the evaluators, and who completed the opening and when. A separately appointed evaluation committee then starts work. An opening with no bids sends nothing.
Tenders	The attendance details shown on the tender's public page. Bid Opening cannot change the tender itself or its deadline.
Supplier portal	One fact: that the opening has started. Only then can a tender-security original or an issuer's confirmation be linked to a bid.
Suppliers	What was read out and, for a supplier that bid, a copy of the final list of bids.
Home page	The tasks of the Accounting Officer, the members and the recorder. Each task clears when the work is done, not when a notice is read.

Bid Opening relies on Tenders for the deadline and any addenda, and on the supplier portal for the sealed bids with their receipts and history; the portal gives it no way to open a bid itself. Separate services unlock the box with the members' participation, check each member's signature, and keep the attendance, minutes and signatures.

Safeguards

- **No early look.** Before the opening starts, nobody at the procuring entity, administrators included, can tell whether there are any bids, how many, who sent them or what they say.
- **No one opens alone.** Every member must be present, and is checked before each bid. The chair cannot act for an absent member, and no administrator can skip a step.

- **A public opening.** The opening cannot start unless the public has been told how to attend.
- **Facts, not judgements.** Figures are recorded exactly as submitted. No bid is corrected, scored or disqualified at the opening.
- **Personal signatures.** Each member signs for themselves. A button, password or tick-box is not a signature.
- **Not held is final.** An opening recorded as not held can never be started or resumed.
- **Fixed once final.** The list of bids is fixed after the last reading, and signed minutes can only be added to.
- **No dead ends.** When something is blocked, the screen says who can fix it and how. There is no "continue anyway".
- **Full history.** Every appointment, arrival, departure, reading, comment, pause and signature is recorded with who did it and when.